

Don't Just Work Hard, Work Smart: Build Smart, Featuring Sue Nokes

Sue Nokes, Advisory Board Vice Chairman, Asurion; Former Chief Customer & Operations Officer, T-Mobile

In any profession, when a team truly works together towards the same goals, with a shared value system, individuals feel personally invested in the task at hand. Pat Summitt was a good friend of mine, and I was privileged to sit in Pat's locker room before the game and at halftime. And over the years, I observed one obvious difference between the championship teams and the non-championship teams. It's called ownership.

The culture of ownership can only be built with intention. This happens when the right people are put in the right position that best suits their talent. And that's exactly what Pat did. Pat always said that you win in life with people.

Let's analyze her example. First, know your team. Even if you have clear goals and a coherent plan, you won't get anywhere if you have the wrong people filling the roles. Working smart requires building smart teams. The best way to build a strong team is to size up your present resources, identify any weaknesses, and identify the resources needed. Knowing your team and knowing yourself will illuminate the areas that you can build up through professional development and the type of person you should recruit to fill the vacant role.

Second, utilize personality profiles. Pat Summitt used an assessment called the Predictive Index to categorize personality traits. She also brought in sports psychologists to help her staff understand individual players on her teams. More importantly, Pat involved her players in the discussions about their personality profiles. Pat talked with her players about how they saw themselves and what they thought about their results. Pat even provided her coaches and the players with her profile so they could better understand her own motivations and techniques.

When you take the same evaluations you request from your team, it helps identify what motivates you, what you love to do, and what zaps your mental energy. Learn how to delegate the tasks that drain you the most so you can focus on what you do the best and what you bring to your team.

And third, learn your team's pressure points. Everyone handles pressure differently, and it's the job of the leader to know how your people respond to pressure before high-pressure moments arrive.

Pat used to say, "It's your chief responsibility as a leader or a manager or CEO to know who you can delegate to and when." When you know your team, their personalities, and how they respond to pressure, you will be able to draw out their talents and put them in situations where they can be most successful.

